

Tylosurus acus

Needlefish



Location W. Atlantic

Length 35 in (90 cm), max 5 ft (1.5 m)
Weight Up to 7¼ lb (3.5 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

beaklike jaws and slender body. It is dark blue or green above and silvery below, and its jaws contain an impressive array of sharp teeth. To escape predators, this agile fish may jump clear of the water. While leaping, it may inadvertently spear boats or even boaters, causing severe injury due to its size and strength. The young may defend themselves by floating motionlessly on the surface in an attempt to mimic seagrass and escape detection.

The largest member of the needlefish family, this species gets its name from its



Exocoetus volitans

Tropical two-wing flyingfish



Location Tropical and subtropical waters worldwide

Length Up to 12 in (30 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

FISH OUT OF WATER



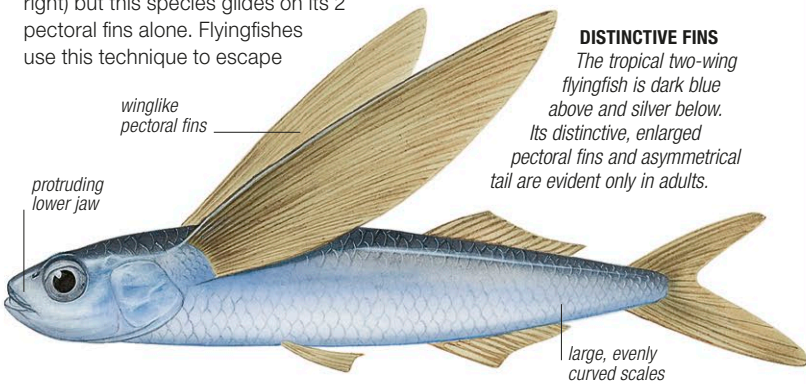
To achieve liftoff, flyingfishes beat their tails rapidly beneath the water for the initial thrust, then extend their pectoral fins to lift them clear of the surface. The lower tail lobe continues to oscillate. At full speed, the fish can glide for up to 12 seconds.

Despite its name, this fish does not actually fly; instead, it glides over the water on specially enlarged and stiffened fins (see panel, right). Some species of flyingfishes have 2 pairs of “wings,” consisting of enlarged pectoral and pelvic fins (see Atlantic flyingfish, above right) but this species glides on its 2 pectoral fins alone. Flyingfishes use this technique to escape

predators such as dolphins, billfishes, and tuna, and may achieve speeds of up to 40 mph (65 kph) in the air.

DISTINCTIVE FINS

The tropical two-wing flyingfish is dark blue above and silver below. Its distinctive, enlarged pectoral fins and asymmetrical tail are evident only in adults.



Cyprinodon diabolis

Devils Hole pupfish



Location S.E. USA (Nevada)

Length Up to 1 in (2.5 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Critically endangered

area of about 215 square ft (20 sq m). Water pollution and fluctuations in the water table threaten its survival. The smallest of all pupfishes, it lacks pelvic fins and the vertical barring seen in most of its relatives. It breeds throughout the year, but rarely lives for more than 12 months.



Found only in a single desert spring in Nevada, this tiny fish has one of the most restricted ranges of any vertebrate. The entire population numbers fewer than 500 individuals and occupies an

Cypselurus heterurus

Atlantic flyingfish



Location Atlantic, E. Indian Ocean, Pacific

Length Up to 16 in (40 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Not evaluated

Also known as the four-wing flyingfish, this coastal species lives in the surface waters and feeds on plankton and small fishes. Unlike other flyingfishes, both the pectoral and pelvic fins are modified for “flight.” By opening out these fins, the four-wing flyingfish can glide over long distances—up to 655 ft (200 m)—to escape predators. In order to propel itself clear of the water surface, it may reach speeds of 37 mph (60 kph). The eggs have long, adhesive filaments by which they attach themselves to seaweed to avoid sinking.



Anableps anableps

Largescale foureyes



Location N. South America

Length Up to 12½ in (32 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Not evaluated



This long-bodied fish has protruding, froglike eyes that are each divided horizontally, allowing it to see above the water and below it at the same time. This enables the fish to hunt equally effectively for aquatic insects underwater or flying insects that have fallen onto the water’s surface. It swims rapidly to escape predators like kingfishers and wading birds, and may jump clear of the water to escape predatory fishes. Female largescale foureyes fish can store sperm and so can lay multiple clutches of eggs.

Poecilia reticulata

Guppy



Location Caribbean, N. South America

Length 2¼–2¾ in (6–7 cm)
Weight Under ¾ oz (5 g)
Sex Male/Female
Status Not evaluated

guppy is very variable in color, often having blotches of blue, red, orange, yellow, and green pigments, as well as occasional spots, bands, or stripes of black. Such variation is greater in the aquarium fish. Very fertile, females may have over 100 young at a time, although the typical brood is 20–40. Adept at feeding on mosquito larvae, the guppy has been widely introduced as an agent of mosquito control.

A popular aquarium fish, the guppy belongs to a family of more than 300 species that are notable for bearing live young. In the wild, the male



Poecilia latipinna

Sailfin molly



Location S.E. North America

Length ½–2 in (1.5–5 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

almost the entire length of the body. A close relative of the guppy (see above), this fish is also a popular aquarium species. Although it is generally olive green, many different color forms have been developed. The back, sides, and dorsal fin have rows of spots, which may merge to look like stripes.

The sailfin molly derives its name from the large dorsal fin that stands up along

